W43580

CO7 TECHNOLOGIES: INFORMATION-SYSTEMS SELECTION

Nura Jabagi and Anne-Marie Croteau wrote this case solely to provide material for class discussion. The authors do not intend to illustrate either effective or ineffective handling of a managerial situation. The authors may have disguised certain names and other identifying information to protect confidentiality.

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It was a crisp fall day in October 2023, and Chantal Pouliot would soon be celebrating her six-month anniversary as the first dedicated human-resources (HR) manager of CO7 Technologies Inc. (CO7), a Montreal-headquartered company operating in the Canadian electricity industry. Born from the ambitious vision of President Christian Cossette and his team, the company had swiftly become a key player in Quebec's electric-power distribution and protection equipment market after acquiring the assets and intellectual property (IP) of three products from Schneider Electric SE (Schneider Electric) in July 2020. Since then, the company had weathered the COVID-19 pandemic and successfully grown from nine to 96 employees through the strategic acquisition in 2023 of Technologies DUAL-ADE Inc. (Technologies DUAL-ADE), in the neighbouring city of Sherbrooke. While the firm's rapid growth had allowed Cossette and his key business partners to see a quick return on their investments, it had also brought challenges. In addition to the increasing complexity of managing CO7's operations and workforce, Pouliot worried that CO7's ability to maintain its unique corporate culture would be threatened by its recent acquisition. Worse, CO7's patchwork of existing information systems (ISs) offered little insight into the issue.

Amid the company's fast-paced growth, Pouliot believed there was a critical need for CO7 to adopt a human-capital management (HCM) system as soon as possible. However, she first had to prepare and present to the management team a business case on her proposed idea before the end of the financial year on December 31. The business case would need to impart a clear understanding of the available HCM systems that could meet CO7's needs, along with a recommendation for the best solution to serve the company now and in the future. She had four options before her: 1) using the existing Odoo enterprise resource-planning (ERP) system's HR application, 2) using the Odoo HR application while integrating a third-party app for payroll, 3) leveraging the HR platform from Payworks, its current payroll service provider, or 4) developing a custom HCM platform.

INDUSTRY BACKGROUND

In 2021, Canada's electricity industry generated 628 terawatt hours, with nearly 68 per cent of this coming from renewable sources, primarily hydroelectric power.[1] As the world's second-largest producer of

[1] "Energy Fact Book, 2023-2024: Clean Power and Low Carbon Fuels," Government of Canada, accessed June 19, 2025, chrome-extension://efaidnbmnnnibpcajpcglclefindmkaj/https://energy-information.canada.ca/sites/default/files/2023-10/energy-factbook-2023-2024.pdf.

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hydroelectricity,[2] Canada's electricity sector was well positioned for continued growth. Population increases and the rising use of electrical appliances, likely driven by the proliferation of smart devices, were expected to drive further demand for electricity.[3] Moreover, Canada's electricity rates remained among the lowest in the developed world, making the sector even more attractive to consumers and businesses seeking electricity cost savings. Nevertheless, the post-pandemic economic slowdown placed additional pressures on the sector and its long-term potential.

Canada's electricity industry was engaged in three main activities: the generation, high-voltage transmission, and low-voltage distribution of electricity. Traditionally, the industry had been dominated by vertically integrated utilities—often provincial Crown corporations[4] holding a monopoly—that were responsible for all aspects of the electricity supply chain, from generation to transmission and distribution. However, from 2010 to 2020, significant changes had reshaped the industry's landscape. Most provinces began unbundling the generation, transmission, and distribution functions, which created separate entities and allowed independent power producers to enter the market, leading to greater competition and innovation. The federal government complemented these changes by investing in research and development (R&D) and the commercialization of new technologies.[5]

In addition to a changing competitive landscape, the Canadian electricity industry benefited from the country's commitment to clean energy. In recent years, government policies encouraged investments in renewable energy, particularly in hydroelectric, wind, and solar power. Moreover, as Canada gradually transitioned away from fossil fuels, the government facilitated this shift by funding green infrastructure projects, promoting transportation electrification, and supporting the development of energy-storage technologies. Meanwhile, Canadian consumers had become increasingly aware of the environmental and health impacts of fossil fuels, resulting in a strong shift in public opinion in favour of green energy solutions. This shift was reflected in their growing adoption of electric vehicles, investment in energy-efficient appliances, and a preference for energy retailers with strong environmental credentials.[6]

COMPANY BACKGROUND

CO7 originated as a spin-off of Schneider Electric, a French multinational specializing in energy management and automation. By acquiring the assets and IP for three types of circuit breakers from Schneider Electric, CO7 took a step toward establishing itself as a Quebec-based company. The acquisition provided CO7 with the opportunity to create jobs and foster growth by leveraging established products and client bases, enabling a less risky start compared with many other start-ups.

In CO7's first year of operation, approximately 80 per cent of its revenue came from manufacturing and selling three product lines acquired from Schneider Electric: fuse-based circuit breakers (Securupt), vacuum station breakers (VOX), and dead-tank station breakers (Doghouse). Despite competing against established industry players including ABB Group (ABB), CooperFriedman Electric Supply Co. Inc., EMA Electromechanics Inc., General Electric Company, Hitachi Ltd. (Hitachi), Hubbell Incorporated, Mitsubishi Electric Corporation, S&C Electric Company, Siemens Aktiengesellschaft, and Toshiba Corporation, CO7 carved out a strong market

[2] "Canada's Energy Futures 2021 Fact Sheet: Electricity," Canada Energy Regulator, accessed April 1, 2024, https://www.cer-rec.gc.ca/en/data-analysis/canada-energy-future/2021electricity/.
[3] "About Electricity," Government of Canada, accessed April 1, 2024, https://natural-resources.canada.ca/our-natural-resources/energy-sources-distribution/electricity-infrastructure/about-electricity/7359.
[4] Crown corporations were government-owned organizations structured as private or independent companies.
[5] Government of Canada, "About Electricity."
[6] "Canada's Climate Actions for a Healthy Environment and a Healthy Economy," Government of Canada, accessed April 1, 2024, https://www.canada.ca/en/services/environment/weather/climatechange/climate-plan/climate-plan-overview/actions-healthy-environment-economy.html.

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presence in a few years. A significant milestone for CO7 was securing a multi-year contract with Hydro-Québec—a government-owned public utility that generated and distributed electricity in the province—as the exclusive supplier of a key product for its overhead distribution systems (an electrical power distribution method that relied on above-ground power lines, typically relying on poles or towers).

Building on its success since 2021, CO7 had recently shifted its focus to global expansion, with the ambition of becoming an international leader in the electrical-distribution, renewable-energy, and microgrid markets. As a Quebec-based company, CO7 benefited from the province's reputation in producing hydroelectricity,[7] which reassured global markets about the quality of its circuit breakers. The company's efforts had already shown promise as it began manufacturing protection equipment for power grids in Australia, England, and Ireland. Alongside investing in R&D to expand its product offerings, CO7 also intensified its diversification efforts by adding complementary products and services to better serve domestic and international markets. To propel its growth, CO7 also planned to acquire complementary businesses and form strategic partnerships. In January 2023, CO7 made its first company acquisition—Technologies DUAL-ADE—which added Switchgear circuit breakers to its product line.

ORGANIZATIONAL STRUCTURE AND LEADERSHIP

CO7 employed 96 people across its two sites in Lachine (a Montreal borough) and Sherbrooke, with 70 per cent of the workforce based in Lachine and 30 per cent based in Sherbrooke—approximately 150 kilometres (km) away. The Lachine plant was responsible for manufacturing the Securupt, VOX, and Doghouse circuit breakers, while the Sherbrooke plant focused solely on producing Switchgear circuit breakers.

The company was organized into several departments, including engineering, production, finance, HR, and sales and marketing. Except for the latter three departments, all others had dedicated teams at the Lachine and Sherbrooke sites. The finance, HR, and sales and marketing departments, based exclusively in Lachine, were responsible for managing operations at both locations.

CO7's management team consisted of three key individuals with complementary expertise in the industrial, manufacturing, and energy sectors, providing a strong foundation for the company's success. The executives—Cossette; François Laurence, vice-president (VP) of finance; and Rouzbeh Rezvani Naraghi, VP of operations—were based at the Lachine site. However, they spent one day each week in Sherbrooke to offer their presence and oversight at both locations (see Exhibit 1).

HCM AT CO7

According to Laurence, from the beginning, CO7's leaders had focused on building a strong, family-centred organizational culture. Their efforts had made a clear impact and employees felt they belonged to a supportive team where each person was valued and motivated to contribute to shared objectives. Factory workers knew that management was willing to step in when extra help was needed. For instance, Laurence regularly assisted on the factory floor during high-volume periods. Moreover, staff felt at ease speaking with leadership and trusted the company's direction. To reinforce openness and collaboration, the company held quarterly meetings and regularly organized family-friendly events, such as paintball and cooking competitions, to encourage team bonding. The leadership saw its culture as a major reason for the low employee turnover and strong company performance. However, as CO7 expanded rapidly, the absence of a dedicated HR professional became increasingly noticeable. This led to the hiring of Pouliot, who, within her first six months, identified several pressing challenges in HCM that needed prompt attention.

[7] "CO7 Technologies: Building on Existing Assets," PME MTL, accessed June 22, 2025, https://pmemtl.com/en/blog/co7-technologies-building-on-existing-assets.

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Recruitment and Onboarding

CO7's growth and the increasing demand for its products created a constant need to recruit new employees, including factory workers, project managers, and back-office staff. Pouliot spent countless hours creating job ads, reviewing applications, organizing interviews, and sending out contracts. Once hired, new employees were also onboarded by Pouliot, with support from each employee's direct manager. From an administrative standpoint, onboarding a new employee meant that Pouliot had to create new roles in Payworks, the company's payroll system. She also had to set up profiles in the ERP system, Odoo. This manual process was time-consuming and required double-entries, which was prone to errors.

Similarly to many companies, CO7 favoured promoting from within to fill leadership roles. This approach not only saved money but also boosted employee morale, enabled company agility, and supported knowledge retention and succession planning. However, while many organizations were adopting digital-talent marketplaces, CO7 still posted jobs on a physical board in the employees' lounge—a method Pouliot questioned owing to its limited visibility.

Training and Development

CO7's growth significantly increased the company's training needs. Training was offered primarily to internal transfers, new hires, and upon request. However, no regular training programs were available to employees after they had been hired, leading to a gap in the systematic refinement and advancement of knowledge and skills within the organization. This lack of ongoing training posed risks, as employees might fall behind on industry developments or miss opportunities to enhance their capabilities. Recognizing this issue, Pouliot began working on a comprehensive plan to forecast short- and medium-term training needs for all employees. Her plan aimed to ensure that training was not only available during key transitions but also integrated into the routine of every employee. She intended to centralize all training information, making it easier to track what training had been completed and identify gaps where further education was needed. This centralized system allowed for better planning, ensuring that employees were consistently equipped with the latest skills and knowledge to pre-empt and support CO7's evolving business needs. Pouliot also explored the possibility of introducing targeted training modules tailored to specific roles, which ensured that the workforce remained agile and capable of adapting to new challenges and technologies.

Skills and Capabilities Management

As CO7 expanded and diversified its projects, it became increasingly difficult to assign the right person to the right project. The ability to understand employees' current skills and capabilities was critical to ensuring the right person was assigned to the right role and project. However, absent a structured system for understanding and managing the skills and capabilities of the workforce, CO7's management had sometimes found itself deploying resources inefficiently, resulting in project delays. A system for managing the organization's skills would not only allow projects to be better allocated but would also improve the efficiency of the recruitment process. Tracking employee skills would also help cultivate employees' career plans. Specifically, CO7 had seen success in promoting factory workers to project-management positions. However, this strategy required better visibility into employees' skills, aspirations, and career goals, which could be facilitated through regular performance reviews.

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Performance Management

CO7's approach to performance management was still in its early stages and had not yet fully adapted to the company's increasing size and complexity. As of 2023, employees underwent a three-month evaluation period after joining the company and received an annual performance review. However, this cadence proved insufficient for effectively managing and developing the workforce as CO7 continued to expand. Additionally, CO7 lacked a robust set of key performance indicators (KPIs) tailored to different organizational roles and functions. Moreover, performance tracking was limited to monitoring attendance and the verbal feedback provided by direct supervisors. Pouliot and Laurence planned to advance CO7's performance-management practices by integrating more data-driven methods, particularly for warehouse workers. By establishing clear, measurable KPIs and systematically tracking them, the company hoped to create a more structured and objective framework for evaluating employee performance. This shift would not only enhance productivity but also support the company's broader goals of fostering employee development, improving operational efficiency, and aligning individual performance with organizational objectives.

Employee Engagement and Post-Acquisition Integration

With the growth and diversification of teams across the company, maintaining the same level of motivation, satisfaction, and commitment as in the early days became challenging. Although CO7 conducted an annual employee survey using a paper-based questionnaire, Pouliot felt this was insufficient. She wanted to send regular surveys and feedback forms to better understand employee attitudes and needs. Moreover, she wanted a dashboard to track employee KPIs related to engagement and other human-capital objectives, which would allow her to visualize and present the data clearly and comprehensively. Such a dashboard would be crucial for implementing a data-driven approach to decision-making regarding human capital at CO7.

The acquisition of the Sherbrooke plant introduced additional challenges. Integrating two distinct teams, each with its own culture and working methods, proved difficult. The Sherbrooke workers had more seniority and experience than those at Lachine, making their retention crucial. However, the deeply rooted culture at Sherbrooke meant that these workers resisted changes in working methods, organizational processes, and ISs. Additionally, a pressing need existed to develop leadership skills among Sherbrooke's workers. Thus, Pouliot devoted much of her time to coaching team leaders, aiming to build a leadership foundation that CO7 could rely on to support not only ongoing business operations but also future growth, which would help bring in new employees and foster more effective leadership.

Human-Capital Data Fragmentation

From its inception, CO7 had relied on Microsoft Word documents and Excel sheets stored on Microsoft OneDrive and the file-storage function of Microsoft Teams to manage employee data. While this approach was manageable when the company had just nine employees, it became increasingly unwieldy as CO7 expanded. Employee data—ranging from personal information and employment history to performance reviews—was dispersed across multiple documents, creating significant challenges in data management. As CO7 grew, this fragmented system further revealed its limitations. Each time a new employee was hired or an existing employee's data changed, Pouliot needed to manually update multiple records. This process involved entering data into both the Excel file that served as the HR database and the payroll system, Payworks. This redundancy not only ate up time but also increased the risk of errors. A single mistake in data entry could lead to discrepancies in employee records, payroll, or tax reporting. Moreover, CO7's decentralized data-management system made it difficult for the HR department to access and analyze employee information efficiently. For instance, compiling data for performance reviews or generating

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reports on employee metrics required Pouliot to sift through numerous documents, increasing the likelihood of missing critical information or making mistakes.

Pouliot also had growing concerns about the security and privacy of sensitive employee information. Storing such data on OneDrive or Teams raised questions about whether these platforms provided adequate protection against unauthorized access or data breaches. As CO7 continued to expand, the potential risks associated with such breaches became more significant, underscoring the need for a more secure and integrated HCM system.

CURRENT IS SOLUTIONS

Odoo

When CO7 set out to choose an ERP, it prioritized user-friendliness. Despite having engineers on its management team, CO7 lacked deep expertise in technology and organizational ISs. Given its limited ability to manage complex technological issues, CO7 sought a solution that was user-friendly and offered them a strong customer support. Although Schneider Electric's ERP platforms included multiple SAP systems and an Oracle ERP, CO7 opted for a less costly, open-source alternative: Odoo. Developed by the Belgian company Odoo SA, Odoo was a suite of business-management tools, including customer-relationship management, e-commerce, invoicing, accounting, manufacturing, warehouse, project management, and stock management. Odoo enabled businesses to automate and track operations centrally, with access from any device, anywhere. One of Odoo's key advantages was its extensive ecosystem of applications, which simplified integrations and reduced technological complexity. Additionally, its unlimited support and maintenance, included in all plans, made it an attractive option for CO7.[8] According to Capterra, a software-review platform, Odoo scored an average of 4.2 stars based on over 1,200 reviews—reinforcing its reputation as a viable alternative to traditional ERP systems.[9] As a European company, Odoo complied with Europe's General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR).[10] For Canadian users, Odoo offered the Odoo Sign feature which would allow CO7 to comply with Canada's Personal Information and Electronic Documents Act (PIPEDA) should it need to gather electronic signatures.[11] Moreover, Odoo offered a list of certified implementation partners in Canada, such as OERP Canada, that could work with Odoo users to ensure full compliance with Canadian federal and provincial privacy laws and regulations.[12]

Odoo offered many different modules and applications (apps).[13] Odoo apps could be hosted on three different platforms: Odoo Online (software as a service, or SaaS), Odoo.sh (platform as a service), or Odoo On-Premises (self-hosted, see Exhibit 2).[14] CO7 chose online hosting through Odoo's SaaS model, paying for five users and 11 modules, including Accounting, Invoicing, Inventory, Purchase, Documents, Manufacturing, Quality, CRM, and Maintenance. CO7 also paid a fee for the Studio app—a toolbox that

[8] "About Us," Odoo, accessed June 22, 2025, https://www.odoo.com/page/about-us; "Pricing," Odoo, accessed June 22, 2025, https://www.odoo.com/pricing.
[9] "Odoo Review 2025: Full Pricing, Overview, And Alternatives," Capterra, accessed June 19, 2025, https://www.capterra.ca/software/135618/odoo.
[10] "General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR)," Odoo, accessed June 22, 2025, https://www.odoo.com/gdpr.
[11] "Odoo Documentation," Odoo, accessed June 19, 2025, https://www.odoo.com/documentation/18.0/applications/productivity/sign/canada.html.
[12] "Implementation Partners," Odoo, accessed June 22, 2025, https://www.odoo.com/partners/country/canada-36.
[13] Apps were software programs designed to perform a specific function directly for a user or, in some cases, for another app. Larger, stand-alone modules were typically referred to as apps, whereas other modules typically served as add-ons to these larger app; "Models, Modules, and Apps," Odoo Docs, Odoo, accessed April 1, 2024, https://www.odoo.com/documentation/17.0/applications/studio/models_modules_apps.html.
[14] "How to Choose Your Hosting Type," Odoo, accessed March 1, 2024,, https://www.odoo.com/blog/business-hacks-1/how-to-choose-your-hosting-type-560).

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allowed users to configure and customize the ERP to CO7's needs without coding knowledge. Customization could range from adding fields in databases to changing user views and automating tasks using the ERP. Studio could also be used to create apps from scratch.[15] The user base at CO7 included members from the finance department, the engineering team, the sales and marketing teams, and various project managers across the company. Although CO7's clients could access Odoo, they were not considered paid users. The annual cost of Odoo for CO7 was approximately CA$13,560[16] until the fall of 2025.

Payworks

To manage its payroll process and pay its employees, CO7 used Payworks, developed by Payworks Inc., a Canadian provider of cloud-based workforce-management solutions for companies operating in Canada.[17] CO7 subscribed to a basic Payworks plan that included external payroll management, time management, and benefits management. All 96 employees at CO7 had a profile in Payworks, containing hiring data, employment contracts, personal information, and other sensitive details. This information formed part of the Payworks employee database, enabling CO7 to manage all employee-related data from a single, centralized location. As a Canadian company, Payworks Inc. was required to comply with Canadian federal and provincial privacy laws and regulations, including PIPEDA.[18]

CO7 processed payroll bi-weekly. CO7's total cost for Payworks was $340 per pay cycle. The process was overseen by Laurence and his assistant. For salaried workers, payroll was automated, but for production employees, manual intervention was required. Specifically, each data entry from the Payworks physical punch clock needed to be reviewed and approved by Laurence. At the end of each pay cycle, Laurence also manually transferred the Payworks payroll report as a journal entry into Odoo's accounting module. The manual transfer of data was tedious and took Laurence an extra half day of work every pay cycle. Additionally, Laurence had to manage employees' vacation days (accrued and taken) manually in Excel. Employees found the vacation-tracking process confusing, and Laurence worried that, as the company grew, the pay and vacation-tracking processes would become even more laborious.

HCM SOLUTIONS

Over the last few weeks, Pouliot had started gathering information on HCM systems that could meet CO7's needs. A quick online search revealed that many of CO7's competitors—including Eaton Corporation plc, Hitachi, and ABB—used SAP or Oracle solutions. Pouliot was interested in these big-name solutions but wondered whether they were out of CO7's budget. The company was still a small or medium enterprise, and it had just spent a considerable amount acquiring the Sherbrooke plant. Pouliot estimated that an acquisition cost of $37,500 was the maximum the company would be willing to commit. She also considered that a total cost of ownership (TCO) of $17,500 per year over three years was acceptable. However, she believed that keeping the TCO at $15,000 or less per year would make it easier to secure leadership's approval for the investment.

[15] "Odoo Studio," Odoo, accessed June 23, 2025, https://www.odoo.com/app/studio.
[16] All dollar amounts are in Canadian dollars.
[17] "Payworks Solutions Overview," Payworks, accessed June 19, 2025, https://www.payworks.ca/solutions/overview.
[18] "PIPEDA Requirements in Brief," Office of the Privacy Commissioner of Canada, accessed June 23, 2025, https://www.priv.gc.ca/en/privacy-topics/privacy-laws-in-canada/the-personal-information-protection-and-electronic-documents-act-pipeda/pipeda_brief/#business.

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Odoo HR Application

Odoo offered an HR app through a subscription model. The app was relatively comprehensive, offering a range of HR functions (see Exhibit 3). As of 2023, the app cost around $1,690. However, CO7's contract with Odoo would soon be expiring, and the company would be changing its subscription model (see Exhibit 4). The new model would offer three plans—Free, Standard, and Custom—all of which included hosting, data management, and unrestricted access to functionality, without hidden costs. Under the new Standard plan, CO7 could have access to all Odoo's apps and modules (including the HR app) for around $33.50 per user per month.[19] Odoo's new plan was attractive as CO7 would soon need to add 25 employees to its Odoo user base. CO7 could work with an Odoo consultant to integrate and configure the HR app to its needs. Based on initial discussions with CO7's Odoo partner, configuring the HR app would likely cost an additional $525 (four hours, at a rate of $150 per hour). Moreover, training users could be expected to cost approximately $3,750.

As Odoo was open source, CO7 could also explore various Odoo-based options to address payroll integration. Specifically, CO7 could purchase a module through the Odoo App Store—an online marketplace where users could purchase custom modules designed to extend the functionality and capabilities of the Odoo ERP (see Exhibit 5).[20] Modules in the app store were generally priced according to the lines of code included in the module, with modules ranging from zero to several thousand dollars.[21] Although the app store did not offer an app directly integrating Payworks with Odoo, it offered a payroll solution called Canadian Payroll, created by the third-party developer Pragmatic TechSoft Pvt Ltd. With this app, there would be no need to manually transfer the payroll report as a journal entry into Odoo's accounting module. However, differently from Payworks, Canadian Payroll could not handle the direct deposit of pay or the remittance of financial information and payments to the federal and provincial government.

The app could be purchased for a one-time licence fee of around $527.20.[22] While the solution was not costly, it would be necessary for CO7 to change its hosting type from Odoo Online to either Odoo On-Premises or Odoo.sh. Moreover, as CO7 did not have the technical capabilities to integrate the module itself, it would need to hire an external consultant. According to CO7's Odoo partner, installation and configuration of the module by the consultant would likely cost an additional $450 (three hours at a rate of $150 per hour), and CO7 would need to consider that any third-party app, like Canadian Payroll, would need to be updated with each new Odoo software update.[23] On average, updating a configured module took a consultant one hour and cost $150. Moreover, the Odoo partner projected that the total cost of training users on the new app would be approximately $1,500.

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[19] "Odoo Pricing," Odoo, accessed March 11, 2025, https://www.odoo.com/pricing.

[20] "Odoo Apps Welcome Homepage," Odoo Apps Store, Odoo, accessed March 11, 2025, https://apps.odoo.com/apps/modules.

[21] It was a common convention—not a formal rule—among Odoo app developers to use the number of lines of code (LoC) as a guideline for pricing modules. The Odoo App Store displayed LoC for each module, and some applications were marketed specifically to developers to help them quickly estimate prices based on line-count. See "Odoo Lines of Code Costs," *Odoo*, accessed July 10, 2025, https://www.odoo.com/forum/getting-started-3/odoo-lines-of-code-costs-219312; "Technical: Module Line of Code (LoC)," *Odoo Apps*, accessed July 10, 2025, https://apps.odoo.com/apps/modules/16.0/to_odoo_module_loc; and "App Module Cost," *Odoo Apps*, accessed July 10, 2025, https://apps.odoo.com/apps/modules/16.0/app_module_cost.

[22] "Canadian Payroll by Pragmatic TechSoft Pvt Ltd.," Odoo App store, accessed June 20, 2025, https://apps.odoo.com/apps/modules/17.0/pragmatic_odoo_canada_payroll.

[23] Odoo released a new version each year that included several new features and improvements. As of 2023, CO7 was on version 16.0, and the latest version of Odoo was version 17.0. Odoo was set to release version 18.0 (v18) in November 2024.

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Payworks HR Platform

Payworks Inc. also offered an HR platform with a variety of functions, including an employee database, a performance-review function, and an onboarding function to effectively welcome and integrate new employees.[24] As the Payworks HR platform was a SaaS solution, gaining access to it was as simple as calling Payworks Inc. and paying for a subscription. At the time, CO7 subscribed to Payworks' external payroll-management, time-management, and benefits-management services. Adding the HR module and other solutions relevant to CO7 could be done à la carte, with costs ranging from $97 to $155.20 per module per pay cycle (see Exhibits 6 and 7).[25] The company also offered free personalized and dedicated support to its service subscribers. However, differently from Odoo SA, Payworks Inc. had a service-level agreement that did not publicly disclose specific details about guaranteed uptime percentages (see Exhibit 8).

Build a Custom Solution

CO7 could explore customized solutions to address its HCM and payroll-integration needs. Such solutions could be used to augment the Odoo HR application or Payworks HR platform, or an end-to-end solution could be built for CO7. A custom solution would integrate seamlessly with the CO7's existing information system and processes. According to Pouliot's discussions with an Odoo developer, developing a simple, end-to-end HCM solution for CO7 would cost around $25,000 and would take a team of external specialists from four to six months to complete. In the short term, CO7 would need to account for initial training costs and deployment time. Over the long term, routine updates to keep the solution aligned with new Odoo versions could take three to five hours annually. Moreover, major Odoo updates—such as database schema changes, API[26] modifications, or core module adjustments—could require significant reconfiguration to maintain compatibility with the HCM system. In such cases, CO7 would also need to account for one to two hours of training to keep employees updated on changes to the solution following Odoo version updates.

DETERMINING NEXT STEPS

Sitting in her office, Pouliot reflected on CO7's current situation. She knew that adopting an HCM system would not only streamline HR processes but also foster a more engaging environment for employees, enabling the company to fully leverage its human capital as it continued to grow. However, the critical question remained as to which option—if any—would best meet CO7's needs. Whichever solution was chosen, to justify the necessary investment and convince the management team, Pouliot would need to convey the current challenges and the transformative potential of a well-chosen HCM system. The team would need a clear understanding of the available systems that could meet its needs, along with a strong recommendation for the best solution to serve the company now and into the future.

With CO7 already considering the acquisition of another company, the pressure to manage an expanding workforce was only going to increase. In Pouliot's mind, deploying a robust HCM system was not just a future goal but an immediate necessity. As she opened her calendar, she wondered how she would find the time to prepare the business case and present it to the management team before the end of the financial year on December 31, 2023. She began to worry as she scrolled through her contacts list, hoping to find a consultant to help her create a compelling business case—one that would persuade CO7's decision-makers of the project's value and the right approach to move forward, whether that meant pursuing a new system or maintaining the current course.

[24] "Odoo Pricing," Odoo, accessed March 11, 2025, https://www.odoo.com/pricing.
[25] "Quote," Payworks, accessed April 3, 2024, https://www.payworks.ca/quote.
[26] Application programming interface.

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EXHIBIT 1: CO7 TECHNOLOGIES INC.'S ORGANIZATIONAL CHART AND LEADERSHIP BIOGRAPHIES, 2023

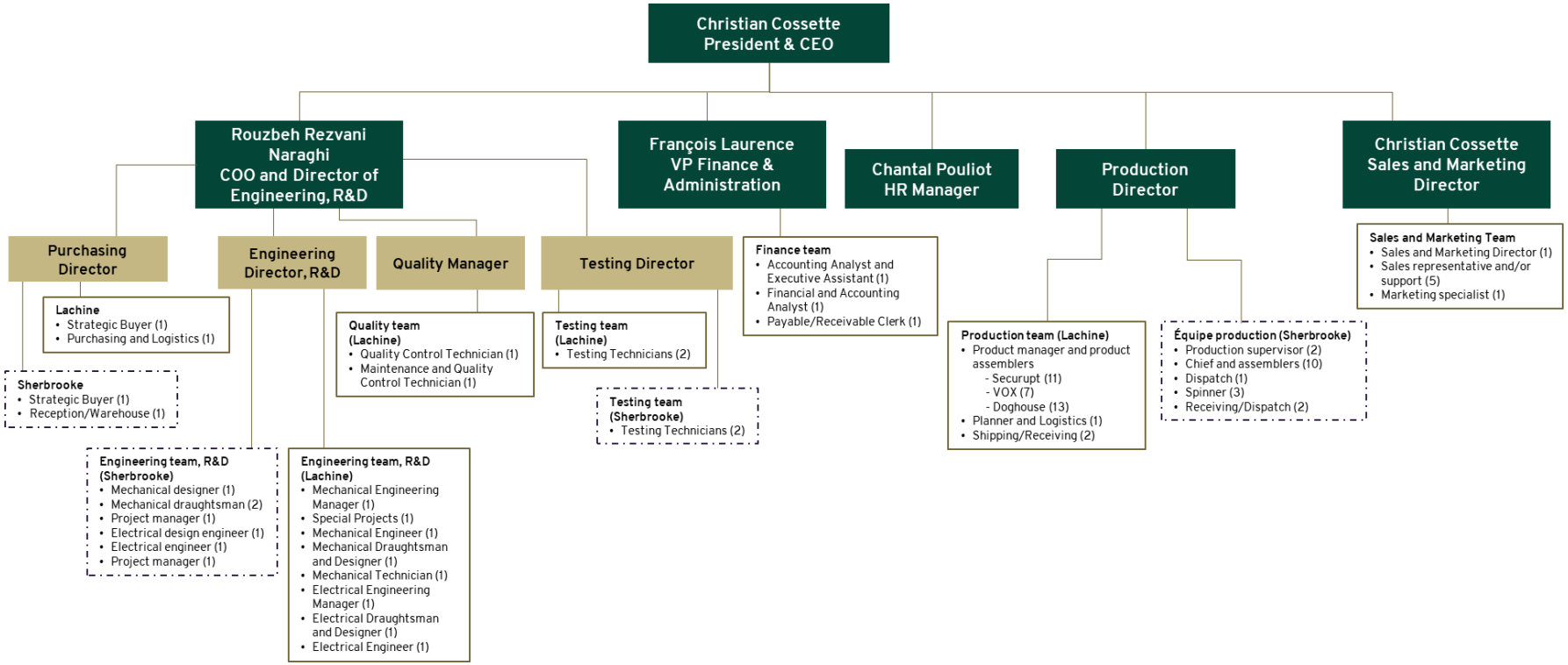

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EXHIBIT 1 (CONTINUED)

Christian Cossette President, CEO, and founder	Cossette had over 25 years of experience in the energy and automation sectors, with a proven track record of managing teams and driving business growth. Before founding CO7 Technologies Inc. (CO7), he served as the director of marketing and engineering at Schneider Electric SE; he also held strategic roles in two Quebec-based small and medium enterprises, where he managed operations and oversaw post-acquisition transitions. He held a master of business administration in high-tech management and a bachelor's degree in electrical engineering. Cossette was named chief executive officer of the year (start-up category) in 2022 by *Les Affaires*, a respected French Canadian business-news outlet.
François Laurence VP of finance and administration, co-owner	Laurence was a senior manager at BDO Canada LLP, an accounting firm, before joining CO7. With a bachelor's degree in both finance and accounting, Laurence had extensive experience in advisory services, particularly in the valuation, acquisition, and sale of businesses, as well as in the analysis of financial projections. His expertise spanned various sectors, including manufacturing technology and industrial equipment, making him well versed in identifying business opportunities, including potential acquisitions and takeovers.
Rouzbeh Rezvani Naraghi VP of operations	Naraghi had over 18 years of experience in electrical-systems engineering and power-quality solutions, along with a decade in engineering management and research and development. Before joining CO7, he was the director of product and applications at Powerside. Naraghi held master's and bachelor's degrees in electrical engineering.
Chantal Pouliot HR business partner	Pouliot previously worked as an HR consultant in both the manufacturing and service sectors, where she developed her vision of HR management centred on fair and equitable personnel-management processes. At CO7, she had the opportunity to implement this vision. Pouliot managed HR at both the Lachine (Montreal) and Sherbrooke sites, dividing her time between locations and working from home two days a week.

Note: CEO = chief executive officer; COO = chief operating officer; R&D = research and development; VP = vice-president; HR = human resources.
Source: Company documents.

EXHIBIT 2: DETAILS OF ODOO HOSTING MODELS

Feature	Odoo Online	On Premises	Odoo.sh
Fast and simple set up	●		●
Easy maintenance of Odoo-certified apps	●		●
99.9% uptime guarantee	●		●
Automated data backups	●		●
Full access to Odoo-certified apps	●	●	●
Third-party apps		●	●
Integrated email server	●		●
Server control		●	●
Built-in tools for developers and system administrators	Not applicable		●

Option 1: Odoo Online (Software-as-a-Service, or SaaS)

With just a few clicks, this cloud-based instance could be up and running, accessible from anywhere at any time. It included a pre-set email server, making setup even more convenient. The main advantage of Odoo Online was its ease of use: there was no need to manage any technical components—Odoo handled everything behind the scenes. The platform was monitored continuously to ensure optimal performance, and it automatically scaled to support a business as it grew. In addition, the support team offered unlimited bug fixes and security updates. Odoo Online operated under a cloud service-level agreement that ensured 99.9% uptime, excluding scheduled maintenance. A company's database was backed up daily, with copies distributed across at least three different servers located on separate continents. Through the database control panel, one could retrieve backups from the past 90 days.

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EXHIBIT 2 (CONTINUED)

A firm retained full ownership of its data, and it was easy to create a duplicate of the live database for testing purposes when implementing new features. All hosted applications were kept up to date with the latest version of Odoo. The online hosting option enabled the installation of certified applications developed and supported by Odoo SA. One such tool, the Studio app, provided a user-friendly interface to tailor views and reports, design new applications, and automate tasks—all without writing code.

With this option, third-party apps and modifications to the source code were not permitted, thus ensuring stability. The Odoo Enterprise plan included hosting, maintenance, support, backups, and upgrades, helping businesses manage costs and avoid unexpected expenses.

Option 2: Odoo On-Premises (self-hosted)

For organizations wishing to manage their own infrastructure, Odoo Enterprise could be installed on a private server. This deployment method was best suited for users with solid technical capabilities, as Odoo SA could not ensure the reliability, speed, or scalability of independently managed environments. While technical guidelines were available in Odoo's documentation, assistance from a certified partner might be necessary for successful local installation.

Managing Odoo On-Premises involved overseeing numerous technical aspects that affected both system performance and operational costs. If working with an external hosting provider, a firm would need to understand the terms of service and any additional fees that might apply. Below were some important questions to keep in mind:

- What level of uptime was guaranteed, and how did it change as users, applications, or data volumes increased?
- What were the backup and disaster-recovery procedures?
    - How and when could backups be accessed, and what were the terms of the data policy?
- Was a test environment available for new feature deployment?
- Who was responsible for maintaining and updating third-party apps? (Odoo SA handled certified apps.)

In a nutshell, Odoo On-Premises granted full control over a firm's installation, enabling the use of certified apps, external applications, or even entirely custom-built solutions. However, it was best for customers with advanced technical knowledge.

Option 3: Odoo.sh (Platform-as-a-Service, or PaaS)

Odoo.sh, maintained by Odoo SA, enabled businesses to deploy a tailored cloud solution with ease; in just a few clicks, the setup (including an email server) could be completed. Designed for more customized Odoo deployments, it supported both certified applications and third-party apps from the Odoo app store. Key features for Odoo.sh included the following:

- An online code editor
- Integration with GitHub
- Continuous integration via "runbot"
- Support for development and staging environments
- Branch-management tools to optimize workflow (tracking, forking, and merging)
- Automatic testing of new code commits

The platform was managed by Odoo SA, providing the same 99.9% uptime guarantee as Odoo Online. Daily incremental backups of a firm's production data were stored in three geographically distributed data centres, with access to backups retained for the previous 90 days. Odoo.sh was highly adaptable, allowing businesses to scale their deployments by adjusting workers, storage capacity, and staging environments. The setup evolved in line with an organization's needs. The bottom line? Odoo.sh merged the user-friendliness of Odoo Online with the customization capabilities offered by On-Premises hosting.

Source: Created by the case authors based on "How to Choose Your Hosting Type," *Odoo* (blog), accessed March 1, 2024, https://www.odoo.com/blog/business-hacks-1/how-to-choose-your-hosting-type-560); "Odoo Cloud - Service Level Agreement," Odoo, accessed March 1, 2024, https://www.odoo.com/cloud-sla; "All Apps," Odoo, accessed March 1, 2024, https://www.odoo.com/page/all-apps; Christian Cossette, "Christian Cossette : opportunité et modernisation," *Les Affaires*, accessed July 10, 2025, https://www.lesaffaires.com/sans-section/christian-cossette-opportunite-et-modernisation-2/.

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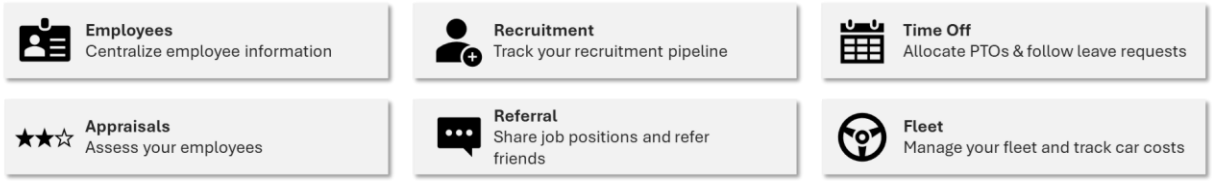
EXHIBIT 3: ODOO APPS AND HUMAN-RESOURCES (HR) FUNCTIONALITY



User profiles and options	
Store and search resumes HR staff could attach each employee's resume to their profile and use the search and filter features on the dashboard to locate staff based on credentials such as education, experience, and certifications. **Track skills** HR could add measurable skills to employee profiles to track their development. Skill categories were customizable and could be updated to reflect progress over time. **Create onboarding and exiting plans** HR could develop and activate onboarding and existing workflows for new hires and departing employees, respectively. These workflows initiated automated sequences across integrated apps to ensure smooth transitions.	**Request time-off** This feature enabled employees to submit time-off requests directly from their profile, without needing to open the Time-Off module. **Request appraisals** Employees and managers could initiate performance evaluations directly from the employee record via the Appraisals module, regardless of whether the review aligned with the company's review calendar. **Send signature requests** HR could send employees a prompt to review and electronically sign documents right from their profile.
Work information	
Assign approvers HR could designate who was authorized to approve expenses, time-off requests, and timesheets on each employee's profile. **Teleworking** HR could set a recurring weekly schedule for work locations, whether at the office, at home, or in another remote location. Once set, this schedule could be automatically repeated each week. **Schedules** HR could specify working hours and schedules for each employee, as well as their time zone.	**Planning roles** HR could designate specific roles that employees were eligible to fill in the Planning module, supporting workforce scheduling. **Generate organizational charts** HR could separate departments and teams into readily accessible organizational charts that appeared on employee profiles. These charts clarified reporting structures, team assignments, and hierarchical positions.
Organization	
Create departments HR could set up departments and assign employees based on a role or function. Departments could be nested within parent units to support structural clarity. **Contract management** HR could store and monitor the status of employee contracts and create reusable contract templates that integrated with payroll and recruitment tools.	**Configure access rights** HR could set different permission levels for staff, managers, and teams to protect sensitive information. **Employee editing** HR could choose whether employees would have restricted edited access or could update their profile data.

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EXHIBIT 3 (CONTINUED)

Organization	
Create positions HR could define and manage all job roles and easily monitor the number of vacancies, applicants, and tasks linked to each role. **Fully customizable** HR could tailor job types, positions, and recruitment workflows to align with an organization's specific needs and hiring procedures. **Publish job openings** One could add or remove job listings from a company website with just one click. **Link to external employment websites** HR could connect job listings to external job boards and track which channels delivered the most relevant applicants using reporting tools. **Recruitment workflow management** HR could build recruitment pipelines for each job role, complete with scheduled meetings, interviews, and calls.	**Calendar integration** HR could book interviews directly from Odoo and sync the schedule with Google or Microsoft Outlook calendars. **Visibility** Applicants could be monitored through the Kanban view to track their stage in the hiring process and identify pending actions or delays. **Integrated communications and activities** HR could reach out to candidates, schedule interviews, or send emails directly from the candidate profile. **Document management** HR could maintain a centralized repository of applicant resumes and employment contracts, improving organization and accessibility. **Backend** HR could manage responses, application emails, and other automation features from within the system.
Recruitment	
Candidate filtering HR could employ questionnaires or assessments to screen applicants and provide actionable insights to the recruitment team. **Self-scheduled interviews** HR could let candidates book their interviews or calls through the website based on the recruiter's availability.	**Sending digital job offers** HR could create and send job offers electronically, which candidates could review, complete, and sign online. **Salary configuration** This feature allowed candidates to customize their compensation packages, including salary, days off, meal vouchers, and more.
Hiring	
Employee integration One could convert a successful candidate into an employee with one click. **Streamlined onboarding process** HR could initiate a tailored onboarding plan as soon as a new hire had been confirmed, which would get them started quickly.	**Employee feedback** HR could gather input from new employees through surveys to improve the recruitment and onboarding experience. **Performance tracking** HR could evaluate team performance and track recruitment funnel metrics, such as applicant sources and pipeline progression.
Employee evaluation (periodic reviews)	
Your people, your advantage Managers could boost motivation by conducting regular evaluations of employee performance. These assessments helped identify growth opportunities and benefited both small businesses and large enterprises. • **Simple tracking**. Managers could view each employee's evaluation stage or assess the status across the entire company. • **Centralized calendar**. One could stay organized with a calendar showing all upcoming reviews and reminders. • **Exportable results**. Managers could convert evaluations into downloadable, printable PDF reports.	
Automated evaluations	
Stay on schedule HR could use automated planning tools to assign evaluation requests to the appropriate team members. It could also define which employee, department, or management level should respond to specific questions, allowing managers to review and finalize input efficiently.	

Source: Created by the case authors based on "All Apps," Odoo, accessed March 11, 2025, https://www.odoo.com/page/all-apps.

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EXHIBIT 4: ODOO'S NEW MODEL PRICING, 2023

Plan	Price (CA$)	Apps included	Hosting model	Free trial
One App Free	$0 (unlimited users)	One app only	Odoo Online	No
Standard	$33.50 user per month	All apps	Odoo Online	Yes
Custom	$51.80 user per month	All apps, plus Studio, Multi-Company, External API	Odoo Online Odoo.sh On-Premises	Yes

Note: API = application programming interface; Odoo's apps included Sales, Marketing, Accounting, CRM (customer-relationship management), Inventory, Project Management, POS (point of sale), and HR (human resources).
Source: Created by the case authors based on "Odoo Pricing," Odoo, accessed March 11, 2025, https://www.odoo.com/pricing.

EXHIBIT 5: ODOO APP STORE

The Odoo App Store was an online marketplace where users could discover and purchase a variety of apps and modules designed to expand the functionality of the Odoo ERP system. It functioned as a central platform for developers to distribute and sell their custom modules, which could be integrated into Odoo to meet specific business needs or enhance its existing features. The store offered both free and paid apps, ranging from simple utilities to extensive modules capable of significantly modifying Odoo's default functionality. These apps were developed by both Odoo SA's in-house team and third-party creators, covering a broad spectrum of industries and business processes. Users could browse the store by category, read reviews, check ratings, and either purchase or download apps directly through the platform. However, third-party apps were not subject to quality control, including adherence to coding standards. This raised significant concerns regarding both security and performance, as these apps were neither verified nor approved. As a result, the quality of apps varied. Nevertheless, the marketplace was particularly beneficial for businesses seeking to customize the Odoo ERP system to fit their unique requirements without having to develop entirely new solutions.

Note: ERP = enterprise resource-planning.
Source: Created by the case authors based on "Odoo Apps Welcome Homepage," Odoo Apps Store, Odoo, accessed March 11, 2025, https://apps.odoo.com/apps/modules.

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EXHIBIT 6: PAYWORKS PLATFORM PRICING MODEL, 2023

Quote details for CO7	
Number of employees	96
Pay frequency	Bi-weekly
Province	Quebec
Total payroll cost	**$242.70**
	Price includes the following services • Employee Self Service • Payroll Preview • Management Reports • CRA/MRQ Filing

Add on services	Key Features	Cost
Absence Management *Tracking of all employees' absences*	• Approved time off auto-flows to Payroll • Request review/edit from a single screen • Rule configuration to fit business needs	$57.60
Applicant Tracking *Hiring has never been so easy*	• Centralized recruitment management • Unlimited job postings and users • Automated flow of candidate data to new employee records	$155.20
Benefits *Manage Payroll, HR, and Benefits at once*	• Integration in real time • Simple premium renewal process • Automatic updates for employee records and benefit changes	Contact an Advisor
HR Advisory Services *Expert support*	• Specialized guidance in HR/legal/financial issues • Exclusive access to a repository of HR resources • Referrals for confidential employee counselling	$97.00
Human Resources *Easily manage employees' life cycles*	• Manage all employees' personal information securely • Document sharing, with "Read & Acknowledge," plus e-signature • Simplified onboarding via workflows and task notifications	$57.60
Managed Payroll Services *Offload payroll to the experts*	• A full-service option for payroll administration, including remittances and year-end filing	Contact an Advisor
Time Management *Integrated scheduling and time capture*	• Auto time capture and data imports from punch system • Create and communicate user-friendly schedules • Break rules, calculations, and premiums are calculated	$144.00
Workforce Analytics *Drive decisions using real-time data*	• Template reports and dashboards • Filters to drill down to view data subsets • Access trends in headcount, absences, turnover, and payroll costs	$63.05

Note: CRA = Canada Revenue Agency; MRQ = Ministry of Revenue Quebec. In addition to the base cost of $242.70, CO7 opted for three add-on services. Specifically, they paid for “Benefits,” “Managed Payroll Services,” and “Time Management” (denoted by the shaded boxes). The base cost for Payworks plus these add-on services accounted for a total cost of $340 per pay cycle.
Source: “Quote,” Payworks, accessed April 3, 2024.

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EXHIBIT 7: PAYWORKS HUMAN-RESOURCES (HR) PLATFORM FEATURES

Streamlined onboarding HR could start new hires off on the right foot with a welcome email and configurable onboarding that provided important company documents at the click of a button. It could also set up automatic notifications to let others know when someone new was joining the team.	**Performance** HR could track employee skills and education, as well as documentation related to reviews and disciplinary action.
Compliance "Read and acknowledge" and e-signature features were provided for company policy documents to ensure the company stayed on track and met compliance requirements.	**Reporting** The platform's comprehensive library of standard reports could be leveraged, or the user-friendly Custom Reports Builder could be used for ad hoc reporting.
Employee database All employee personal information could be managed from one location, including licences and certifications, emergency contacts, and company asset tracking.	**Organizational chart** This feature let firms visualize employee-to-employee relationships and keep track of a growing company.
Online filing cabinet This feature locked away employee documents and company property in Odoo's cloud-based database. Staff had access to this information when they needed it, all from their desks.	**Notifications** HR could save time by using smart features like pre-defined and scheduled notices when changes occurred in employee information (or anything else that required a reminder).
	Benefits Companies could integrate with the platform's partner plans or streamline administration with the current insurance provider for serious time savings.

Source: Created by the case authors based on "Human Resources," Payworks, accessed April 3, 2024, https://www.payworks.ca/solutions/human-resources.

EXHIBIT 8: PAYWORKS INC.'S SECURITY AND GOVERNANCE

- **Two Canadian data centres**. With the Payworks platform, a company's data stayed in Canada. Back-up media was also stored at a Canadian secure document-management firm.
- **Third-party audits**. Payworks Inc. adhered to best practices in funds management and compliance, including annual external independent audits on financial performance and a broad range of internal controls.
- **Responsible funds management.** Not only were government remittances submitted directly to the CRA on Payworks Inc.'s clients' behalf, but its frequency exchange program with the CRA eliminated late remittance penalties for clients.
- **Disaster recovery**. The company maintained a disaster-recovery site and business continuity plan in case of damage or pandemic situations.
- **User-based security**. The company supported multi-user access with user-based security.
- **Two-factor authentication.** Information security protocols and standards such as two-factor authentication were employed to safeguard personal and operational data.

Note: CRA = Canada Revenue Agency.
Source: Created by the case authors based on "Security & Governance," Payworks, accessed April 3, 2024, https://www.payworks.ca/about-us/security-governance.

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